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It is an interesting conundrum: how is it that India, with some of the most capable rocketry and ballistic missile programmes in the world, does not have an indigenously designed, world-class assault rifle—the infantryman's basic weapon. The answer is a mix of factors—persistent flaws in indigenous designs, dithering of the Indian Army over the exact type of weapon it wants and unrealistic demands from weapons manufacturers. India is the world's largest user of small arms (under which assault rifles are categorised), with approximately two million rifles currently in use. The Indian military and paramilitary forces use a variety of assault rifles, such as the INSAS (Indian Small Arms System, the standard issue personal weapon of the Indian soldier), AK-47, M4A1 Carbine, T91 assault rifle, SIG Sauer 716, and Tavor. INSAS forms the major chunk of India's small arms inventory, with close to one million rifles in use. The armed forces use 810,000 assault rifles for the three services, out of which the army alone uses 760,000 rifles.

2 MILLION

APPROXIMATE NUMBER OF ASSAULT RIFLES THAT THE INDIAN MILITARY, PARAMILITARY AND POLICE FORCES ARE USING CURRENTLY

72,000

NO. OF SIG SAUER 716 RIFLES CLEARED FOR IMPORT BY THE DEFENCE MINISTRY, WITH THE ARMY USING AN EQUAL NUMBER

Assault rifles, designed for military use, can function both as a semi-automatic weapon (which fires a single bullet with each pull of the trigger) and a fully-automatic one (that fires continuously until the trigger is released). In a major advancement from older, bolt-action rifles, semi- and fully-automatic rifles allow for a higher rate of fire by using the energy of each fired bullet to eject the spent cartridge and load a new one. The Indian military's two-decade-long search for a reliable assault rifle has much to do with the unsatisfactory performance of the INSAS, which was developed by the Defence Research and Development Organisation (DRDO), manufactured by the state-run Ordnance Factory Board (OFB) and has been in service since 1998. Soon, multiple defects were reported—repeated jamming and stoppage, bursting cartridge cases (the metal encasing of every bullet) and cracking of the rifle's barrel (the metal tube through which the bullet travels after being fired). As early as 1999, during the Kargil War, Indian soldiers complained about cracking of the polymer plastic magazine (the box that holds a given number of cartridges/ bullets that are fed into the rifle) in the cold weather. Gradually, more complaints streamed in—jamming during high-altitude operations in Siachen and the Kashmir Valley, as well as malfunctioning during anti-Naxal operations in the forests of central India. Gradually, the army stopped using it during counter-insurgency operations in Jammu and Kashmir, going instead for the trusted AK-47, known for its ability to withstand extremes of weather conditions and duration of use in a single spell.

Soon after Kargil, the army started its search for a suitable replacement to the INSAS. That quest has taken various shapes in the past 25 years, including an upgraded version of the INSAS and another indigenous rifle, which were tried and discarded. Amidst a debate over the required calibre of a rifle, demands for imported rifles with interchangeable barrels with varying calibres were also raised and dropped. The prolonged uncertainty has now yielded an obvious solution—import of a foreign weapon.

In December 2023, the Indian Army got the approval to import more than 72,000 7.62 x 51 mm calibre (the diameter of the bullet x the length of the cartridge) Sig Sauer assault rifles in a Rs 840 crore deal from the US through the 'emergency procurement' route. However, these are not the military's first Sig Sauers—under a Rs 694 crore deal signed by the defence ministry in February 2019, 72,400 assault rifles were imported and are being used by soldiers along the Pakistan and China borders.